

From Bureaucracy to Platform-Enabled Adhocracy

A Framework for Problem-Based People Governance

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Abstract

Traditional public governance has largely been organized around permanent institutions and hierarchical bureaucracies. While such structures remain essential for law, public authority, standards, and institutional continuity, they can face limitations when addressing complex, cross-sectoral, and rapidly changing public problems. This paper proposes Platform-Enabled Adhocracy as a conceptual approach to problem-based governance and introduces Platform-Enabled People Governance (PEPG) as a framework for supporting its implementation. The central principle is a shift from organization-centered governance toward problem-centered governance, in which temporary and distributed networks can emerge around publicly identified problems.

Keywords: Platform-Enabled Governance; Adhocracy; Bureaucracy; Problem-Based Governance; Digital Governance; Participatory Governance; Network Governance; PEPG

1. Introduction

Public governance has historically depended on permanent institutions with predefined responsibilities. This model provides continuity and authority, but public problems often cross organizational boundaries and require capacities distributed across society. The paper examines how governance can complement permanent institutions with the ability to dynamically organize people, expertise, organizations, and resources around specific public problems.

2. From Organization-Centered to Problem-Centered Governance

Traditional bureaucratic logic generally begins with an existing organization and routes a problem through departments and procedures. The alternative proposed here begins with the problem itself, identifies relevant capacities, and enables a temporary governance network to form around the requirements of that problem.

Figure 1. Organization-Centered vs. Problem-Centered Governance

Traditional Bureaucracy: Organization → Department → Procedure → Problem → Action

Platform-Enabled Adhocracy: Problem → Capacity Discovery → Temporary Network → Action

Figure 1. Conceptual comparison between organization-centered bureaucracy and problem-centered governance.

3. Bureaucracy and Structural Limitations

Bureaucracy remains essential for legal continuity, professional specialization, standardized procedures, and accountability. However, complex problems may expose limitations related to organizational boundaries, slow capacity mobilization, centralized implementation, and concentrated oversight. The objective is not to abolish bureaucracy, but to complement it with a more adaptive problem-based capability.

4. Adhocracy and Flexible Organization

Adhocracy describes flexible organizational forms that can emerge around projects, missions, innovation, or temporary challenges. This paper extends the logic of adhocracy from organizational management toward public governance, asking how distributed societal capacity can be organized dynamically around public problems.

5. Digital Platforms as Governance Infrastructure

Digital infrastructure enables communication, collaboration, verification, voting, reporting, and coordination across geographic and organizational boundaries. PEPG is platform-enabled but not platform-confined: different governance activities may occur across different platforms while shared governance services provide coordination and accountability.

6. Platform-Enabled Adhocracy

Platform-Enabled Adhocracy is defined as a form of problem-based governance in which digital infrastructures enable citizens, experts, institutions, communities, and organizations to rapidly form, coordinate, transform, and dissolve temporary networks around specific public problems.

Figure 2. Conceptual Components of Platform-Enabled Adhocracy	
	ADHOCRACY — Flexible and temporary organization
+	
	DIGITAL INFRASTRUCTURE — Communication and coordination
+	
	PEOPLE GOVERNANCE — Participation throughout the governance cycle
=	
	PLATFORM-ENABLED ADHOCRACY

Figure 2. The three conceptual components of Platform-Enabled Adhocracy.

7. Platform-Enabled People Governance (PEPG)

PEPG supports participation throughout the governance cycle: problem detection, registration, definition, redefinition, validation, verification, solution development, capacity discovery, resource mobilization, implementation, oversight, and public reporting. Participation therefore extends beyond voting into practical problem solving.

8. The PEPG Problem Layer

The PEPG Board functions as a structured problem layer. Problems can be registered, validated, negatively evaluated, redefined, connected to sub-problems, or separated when they have been incorrectly defined. This recognizes that defining a problem is itself a governance process.

9. The Three-Layer Architecture

The proposed architecture consists of an Institutional Layer, a Digital Coordination Layer, and a Dynamic Adhocratic Layer. Permanent institutions provide law and authority; digital services provide coordination; temporary networks mobilize distributed societal capacity.

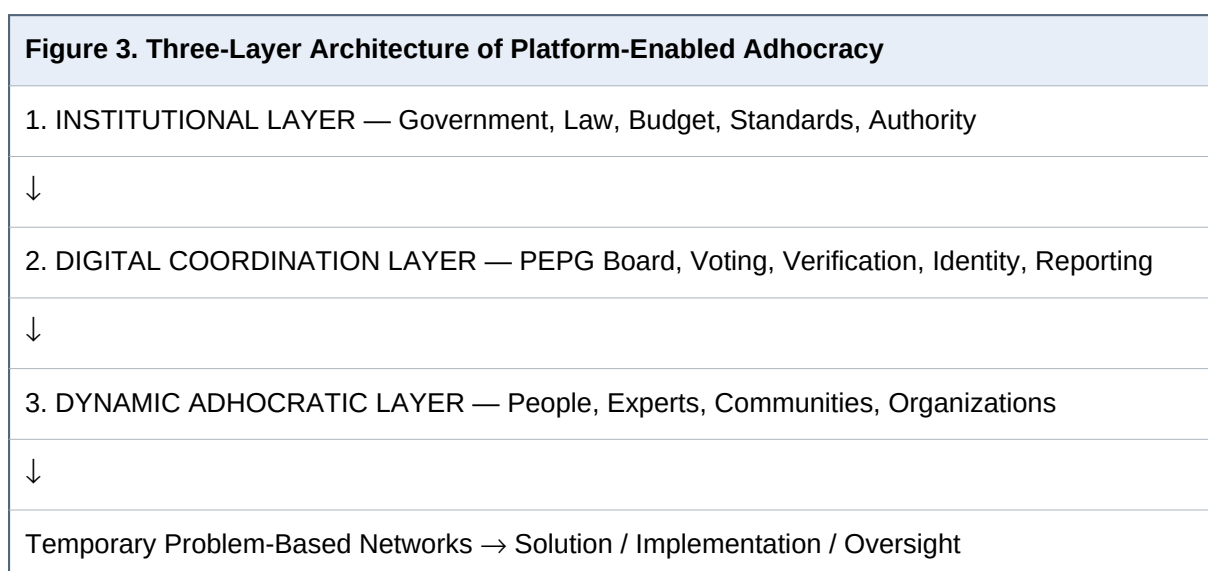


Figure 3. The proposed three-layer architecture connecting institutions, digital coordination, and dynamic societal networks.

10. Problem-to-Action Lifecycle

The lifecycle begins with problem detection and registration, continues through definition, validation, verification, capacity discovery and network formation, and proceeds to solution development, resource mobilization, implementation, distributed oversight, public reporting, and eventual transformation or dissolution of the temporary network.

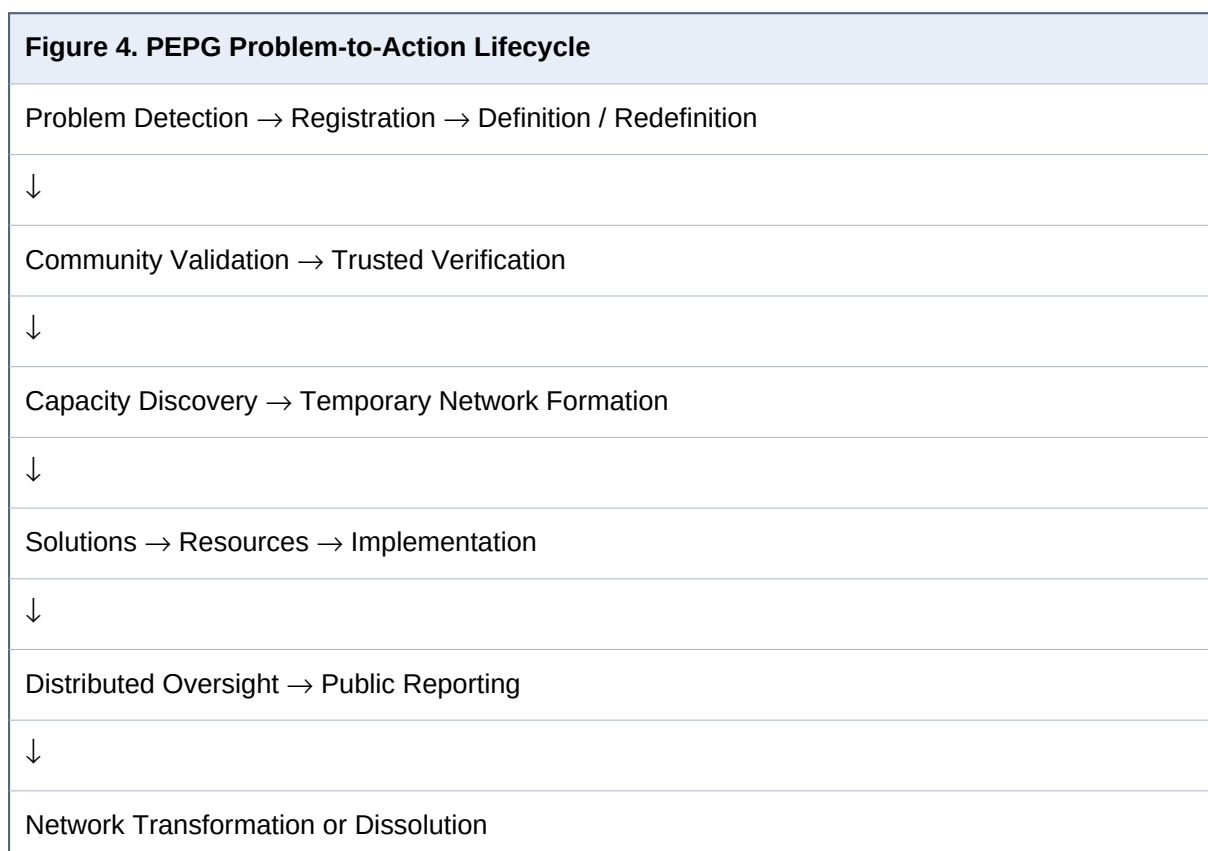


Figure 4. Lifecycle of a problem-centered governance network from problem detection to transformation or dissolution.

11. Government and Society as Complementary Systems

PEPG does not propose government versus society. It proposes government plus society plus digital coordination. Permanent institutions retain legal authority and public accountability while societal networks contribute distributed knowledge, expertise, implementation capacity, and independent oversight.

12. Potential Advantages and Risks

Potential advantages include faster mobilization, distributed capacity, flexibility, scalability, reduced concentration in solution development and oversight, transparency, and resilience. Risks include misinformation, fake identities, coordinated manipulation, privacy concerns, digital inequality, and platform capture. These require institutional, technical, and procedural safeguards.

13. Conclusion

The proposed transition is not from government to the absence of government. It is from governance centered exclusively on permanent organizations toward governance capable of dynamically organizing distributed capacity around public problems. The central proposition is: Organization → Problem can be complemented by Problem → Network → Action.

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